English Channel. It was using some of the unexploded V-2 rockets, called Operation Backfire, that the British started their missile and rocket programmes, which continue to be heavily dependent on the Americans.

I knew Dadieu as a close associate of Wernher von Braun who developed the V-2 engine. Dadieu was also a friend of Sarabhai—both compelling reasons for me to get close to him. Whenever Dadieu came to India, I would try to strike a conversation with him about V-2, thinking that he, as a liquid propulsion scientist would know much about the wonderful rocket of the times. The man was taciturn. Whenever I asked about the rocket, Dadieu, who was fluent in English, would feign that he could not follow me, and would switch to German. Only much later I realised the reason for Dadieu's reticence: he had worked closely with von Braun to make V-2 rocket that sent shivers down the spine of England and her allies during the war. He simply did not want to talk about his brainchild whose versatility prompted the US and its allies to impose sanctions on Germany to stall its rocketry.

When it came to economy of words, no different was Dadieu's companion Muller who kept visiting India, too, frequently to make me wonder about his intentions. I still don't know what brought him to ISRO so often, though we did not strike a deal with him.

After Sarabhai's death, Dhawan, the new ISRO chairman, took forward the French collaboration attempt. Following my outburst and the resignation episode at the ISRO guest house in Chennai, after the failure of the three-tonne liquid engine test, I worked harder on the possible tie-up with SEP, France. After more than a year of correspondence, when Souffle and Morin mentioned their plans to upgrade M40 to 55 tonnes, we found an opportunity to collaborate and learn.

Besides trying to get some money from us, the French were also driven by a sense of competition with the US and the USSR, who were making great strides in rocketry. And they were competent to put themselves on a par with the Americans because of their sheer capabilities in developing flying machines. Concorde was a classic example of French expertise in aviation. The Americans had made supersonic fighter planes, but making a